

Positivism, interpretivism, realism, pragmatism — naming your stance

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Research philosophy is the system of assumptions about the nature and development of knowledge that a study adopts. Saunders' 'research onion' places philosophy as the outermost layer, because every later choice — approach, strategy, method — follows from it. The four stances most used in business research are positivism, critical realism, interpretivism and pragmatism, each carrying its own view of what counts as valid knowledge (Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill, 2019).

POSITIVISM & REALISM

Positivism: reality is objective and measurable; the researcher is detached; law-like generalisations are the goal. Critical realism: an objective reality exists but is observed imperfectly through fallible human perception, so we theorise underlying mechanisms.

INTERPRETIVISM & PRAGMATISM

Interpretivism: reality is subjective and socially constructed; the researcher seeks meaning and is part of what is studied. Pragmatism: the research question is central; whatever combination of methods best answers it is legitimate.

Your philosophy is a declaration, not decoration. Examiners do not want a textbook tour of all four stances. They want you to name the one your study adopts, and show that every downstream choice — sampling, instrument, analysis — is consistent with it. One coherent paragraph beats four descriptive ones.

Stance	View of reality	Typical logic	Typical methods
Positivism	Single, objective	Deductive	Surveys, experiments
Critical realism	Objective but layered	Retroductive	Mixed, case-based
Interpretivism	Multiple, constructed	Inductive	Interviews, ethnography
Pragmatism	What works	Abductive	Mixed methods

STATE IT PLAINLY

Write 'This study adopts an interpretivist philosophy' and then justify why the question demands it. Ambiguity here weakens the whole chapter.

ALIGN DOWNWARD

Your philosophy must fit your methods. Interpretivism with a large anonymous survey is a mismatch examiners spot immediately.

REFLEXIVITY

Under interpretivism especially, acknowledge your own role and potential bias in shaping the data and its interpretation.

Common pitfalls. (1) Describing all philosophies but committing to none. (2) A philosophy that contradicts the chosen method. (3) Treating 'philosophy' as a box to tick rather than the foundation of the design. (4) Copying a stance from another dissertation without checking it fits.

REFERENCES

Saunders, M., Lewis, P. and Thornhill, A. (2019) *Research Methods for Business Students*. 8th edn. Harlow: Pearson. · Bryman, A. and Bell, E. (2015) *Business Research Methods*. 4th edn. Oxford: Oxford University Press. · Crotty, M. (1998) *The Foundations of Social Research*. London: SAGE.